

Reflective Essay

An Important Decision I Made

Due to my genetics, I have been predisposed to a higher risk of psychosis and hallucinations. However, for a long time I was never even aware of this condition and the effects it was having on me. Moreover, due to a lack of information and communication from my family, I believed all of my experiences relating to hallucinations or the strong sense of panic they prompted were entirely ordinary. Nevertheless, as I got older, I began to take notice of behaviours that exacerbated my experiences by speaking to people and sharing my experiences. There were many things that increased these events that I experienced, most prominently I noticed that my caffeine intake increased the severity and frequency of the panic these experiences brought on. I noticed this as I was consuming energy drinks such as Monster and Redbull most days. After being warned about the health risks by concerned friends, I had decided I needed to considerably decrease my caffeine in-take, if not stop it altogether.

Module Application To Decision

Having completed this module on reasoning and decision making, and reflecting on this particular decision I needed to make, I feel better able to assess this decision. Looking at this decision with the knowledge I have acquired, I believe there was a degree of cognitive dissonance operating within my belief system; cognitive dissonance occurs when an individual's beliefs and actions are misaligned (Festinger, 1962). I knew, through an effort of deductive reasoning, that consuming large amounts of caffeine caused me to have adverse mental health side effects, yet I continued to consume a high level of caffeine anyway. The benefit of hindsight makes this dissonance much more apparent to me than it was at the time, and highlights the cause for action. Comparing this approach to my initial, naive approach, being able to highlight the dissonance in the cause and effect relationship of my beliefs and actions would likely decrease my initial hesitation.

Furthermore, Halpern's model for critical thinking (Halpern & Dunn, 2023) indicates that identifying and interpreting the situation are the first steps in making informed decisions. The model also highlights the importance of avoiding cognitive bias; in my original attempt at solidifying this decision, I did not look for disconfirming evidence, a common dilemma in critical thinking (Halpern & Dunn, 2023). Whilst I noticed that the mental health issues worsened with a higher intake of caffeine than without, at the time I did not consider any other factors that might have been exacerbating the situation. For example, stress was a large factor that affected my mental health and that I had not accounted for. This is important as research using fMRI suggests that stress can lead to less-informed decision-making (Maier et al., 2015; Nagappan, 2016).

In order to avoid this mistake in my informed reimagining of the situation, I calculated the probability of a high caffeine intake affecting my mental health using Bayes Theorem. Bayes Theorem aids in understanding the probability of any situation given the already gathered information (Bayes & Price, 1763) therefore by applying it to this particular decision, the

outcome would aid me in making an entirely rational approach. In application of Bayes Theorem, I estimated the following; The chance of an unusual experience on any given day is 20%; The day of the unusual experience, I had a high caffeine energy drink. The chance of me having a high caffeine energy drink on any given day is 65%; On days when I have an unusual experience, I have had a high caffeine energy drink 90% of the time. After working out the equation, the probability of an unusual experience or hallucination given the probability of high caffeine intake was an estimated 55%. The rational decision would be to eliminate the probability of the high caffeine intake by eliminating the intake altogether, which in the end is the decision I made. Nevertheless, this equation solidifies the rational weight of the decision, and furthermore had I made this decision whilst being informed of this, it would have influenced my confidence in making the decision.

A Problem I Solved

Whilst attending university for the first time, I had experienced financial hardship during my first semester. This resulted in me having to drop out of my course entirely, which was an incredibly difficult decision to make. After dropping out, this confronted me with a problem; I no longer had any solidified plans for my future. Eventually, I had moved on from the initial financial issues I had experienced at university, so much so that I had even moved out of my parents house and was supporting myself in a different city. Nevertheless, I still felt directionless without my original goals of graduating within the next few years.

I figured out the solution to my problem after speaking to a coworker who studied online. I quickly realised that I could do the same, and that I could still earn my degree despite the abrupt change of course I had taken. Reapplying to university online this time challenged me to make lifestyle changes that demanded more responsibility from me than I had experienced in years. Navigating those changes was challenging, but in the end supported me more than just in my pursuit of education. Between recognising the problem and solving it, I had also recognised a series of intermediary steps that I needed to take, such as prioritising my mental and physical health, reducing bad habits such as drinking and my poor sleep schedule. Additionally, I reconfigured my working routine to allow time for my studies, which also meant a reassessment of my budget. It was only until these had been reformed that I reached the solution to my problem, securing a place studying Psychology at the Online University of Essex.

Module Application To Problem-Solving

Having completed this module on reasoning and decision-making, I have been able to reapproach this problem afresh. Initially, my first instinct is to acknowledge the type of problem this particular issue presents as. I can recognize that, despite the longevity and nuances of the possible solutions, this problem is ill-defined; this means that despite the presumed simplicity of the problem, there are many ways to go about solving said problem (Halpern & Dunn, 2023). Within this context, I understand now that there are multiple solutions to reaching the desired outcome of revitalising my sense of purpose through education. Nevertheless, now that the problem type is identified, solving the problem becomes the beginning of the next step.

Newell and Simon (1970) suggest that there are multiple sources that one can use as the preliminary step to the beginning of solving a problem, also known as creating a problem space. Noting the structure of this problem, the most useful source of information available to me would be past experience, due to my past experience attending and eventually dropping out of uni previously; Hill-Briggs (2003) also highlights the importance of utilising past experiences in order to problem-solve. By using this previous experience, I can begin to highlight possible obstructions and personal needs related to this problem. Being able to utilise the valuable asset of my past experience would have been beneficial in helping me understand the challenges that this problem posited. Furthermore, by already having experience with this type of problem, I can plan around these challenges expectantly in order to choose the best course of action. To add, this prior experience would have also allowed me the space for a more creative approach to the issue, for example instead of waiting until I had moved out I would have understood that I would have been better equipped to start studying online whilst still at home. Additionally, with the benefit of hindsight, the knowledge this course has equipped me with would have decreased the time it took me to reapply for university significantly by increasing my confidence in finding creative and imaginative solutions to my problems.

Additionally, due to the knowledge I have accrued during this module, I know that this is not the only way to approach this problem. At the time of the problem occurring, it caused me a lot of stress not only to attempt something that felt much bigger than any other problem I'd ever faced, but also to attempt something again after already failing at it once. An alternative approach known as analogical transfer, a type of far transfer, utilises analogies to better understand the complexities of one problem by picturing it as another (Reeves & Weisberg, 1994). An example of this for my problem could be likening my reattempt at university education to a sport like football; missing my first attempt at a goal does not mean the game is over. Being able to make this comparison during my naive attempt at solving this problem likely would have alleviated my insecurities about trying again by helping me reframe the problem and understand that it is okay to fail so long as I try again.

Overall, by completing this module on reasoning and decision-making, I have been able to effectively reimagine the parameters of the problem at hand in ways that utilise the methods and theory available to me. Additionally, I have also been able to reimagine approaching a prior decision that I had made by applying Bayes Theorem and rational thinking whilst also regarding the possible obstacles present during the decision-making process. By reflecting on these through the lens of what I have learned, I have been able to better approach my decisions and problems in an informed and creative manner.

Word Count: 1591

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